Kin selection

The term “kin selection” was first used by British biologist John Maynard Smith in 1964. It is the evolutionary strategy that favors the reproductive success of an organism’s relatives, prioritizing them above unrelated individuals. It occurs when an organism engages in (often) self-sacrificial behavior that benefits its relatives. Charles Darwin was the first to discuss the concept when he wrote about the apparent paradox represented by altruistic nonbreeding social insects, such as worker honeybees, which leave reproduction to their mothers. British evolutionary biologist William Donald Hamilton proposed that bees, for example, behave in an altruistic manner—assisting others in reproduction—when the genetic closeness of the two bees and the benefit to the recipient outweigh the cost of altruism to the giver. This is called Hamilton’s Rule.